# The passive voice

**Objective:** To transform active sentences into the passive and to use the passive to describe actions related to waste and recycling when the doer is unknown or unimportant.

**The idea in two lines:** In the passive, the object of the active sentence becomes the subject. We form it with **be** + **past participle**, keeping the tense of the active verb in the verb *be*.

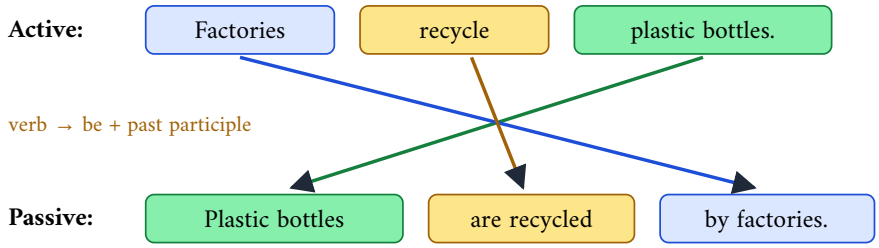



Figure 1: The object becomes the subject, the verb becomes be + past participle, and the doer moves after "by".

## 🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Form:** subject + *be* (in the tense of the active verb) + past participle (+ by agent).
2. **Present simple:** am / is / are + PP: *Paper is collected every week.*
3. **Past simple:** was / were + PP: *The bins were emptied yesterday.*
4. **Present perfect:** has / have been + PP; **future**: will be + PP; **modals**: must / should / can be + PP.
5. **The agent** (by + doer) is omitted when it is unknown, obvious or unimportant (*people, someone, they*).
6. **Use:** the passive is common in scientific and environmental texts because the focus is on the action.

### 🟢 Examples

1. Turn into the passive: "People throw tons of food away." **Answer:** Tons of food *are thrown* away. **Explanation:** present simple; "by people" is dropped.
2. "The municipality built a recycling centre." **Answer:** A recycling centre *was built* by the municipality.
3. "We must reduce waste." **Answer:** Waste *must be reduced*.

### 🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Changing the tense: the tense of *be* must match the active verb.
- Forgetting **be**: *Bottles recycled* ✗ → *Bottles are recycled* ✓.
- Wrong past participle of irregular verbs: *throwed* ✗ → **thrown** ✓.
- Keeping *by people / by someone*: it adds nothing.

### 🟡 Quick review

- Object → subject.
- be (same tense) + past participle.
- Modal + be + PP.
- Agent with by, only if it matters.
- Check agreement: is / are, was / were.

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